QHACKATHON

Participant Handbook

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Welcome to the Q-volution Hackathon!

Over the next week, you will learn from industry leaders, form global teams, and build quantum solutions for real-world problems.

This handbook contains everything you need to successfully navigate the Bootcamp and the Weekend Sprint. Please read it carefully.

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Quick Start Checklist

☑ Join the Discord Server

- Join the Girls in Quantum Discord server: Click Here
- Important: You will not see the hackathon channels immediately.
  - Navigate to the **#hackathon_checkin** channel under the **Lobby** category and create a ticket. A Q-Organizer will assign you a Q-Hacker role and this will unlock the private **Q-Hackathon** category.

☑ Create your Aqora Account

- Register for a free account on **Aqora**.
- Note on Aqora: We will use Aqora only for reading the official Challenge details and submitting your final projects. Please use your local IDE (VS Code, etc.), Google Colab, or the IBM Quantum Lab.

☑ Say Hello!

- Introduce yourself in the **#lounge** and share where you are from!

Bootcamp Schedule

All times are in Eastern Time (New York) . Please convert to your local timezone!
Note that the underlined text is clickable.

February 23, 2026

Mon	11:30 AM	*Opening Announcement on Discord*
Mon	09:00 PM	***Keynote: Maria Salatino, Rigetti***

February 24, 2026

Tue	11:00 AM	***Technical Workshop: Cassandre Notton, Quandela***
Tue	12:00 PM	*Guided Team Formation & Networking (Discord)*

February 25, 2026

Wed	10:00 AM	***Classiq Resource Watch Party***
Wed	11:00 AM	***Rigetti QAOA Resource Tour***
Wed	11:59 PM	🚨 *HARD DEADLINE - Final Track Selection*

February 26, 2026

Thu	10:00 AM	***Keynote: Gloria Clausen, Infleqtion***

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Sprint & Judging

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February 27, 2026

Fri	09:00 AM	*HACKING BEGINS! (Challenge PDFs unlock)*

February 28, 2026

Sat	09:00 AM	*Mentorship Block 1 (EU/Asia Friendly)*
Sat	03:00 PM	*Mentorship Block 2 (Americas Friendly)*

March 1, 2026

Sun	03:00 PM	*HARD SUBMISSION DEADLINE*

March 7, 2026

Sat	10:00 AM	***Closing remarks***
Wed	10:10 AM	***Keynote: Maria Violaris, OQC***
Wed	10:25 AM	***Top 5 finalist pitches begin***
Wed	11:30 AM	***Winner announcements and Best Project Award***

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Team & Track Selection

Team Rules:

Teams must consist of **3-5 members.** You cannot work alone.
If you applied without a team, use the **#team-formation** channel on Discord to find teammates with complementary skills (e.g., mix beginners with experienced coders!).

Locking in Your Track:

By Wednesday, **Feb 25 at 11:59 PM ET**, your team captain must formally select which Track (A, B, C, or D) your team will compete in via the Aqora platform. **You can only submit a project for one track.**

Challenge Tracks & Pre-requisites

Track A: Rigetti Computing (Advanced)

- **Theme**: Energy Grid Optimization
  - Maximizing the Power Energy Section using QAOA

- **Difficulty**: Advanced
  - Requires strong Python/Qiskit/pyQuil knowledge.

- **Special Restriction**: Due to hardware limits, **only 10 teams** will be granted access to Rigetti's Ankaa-3 QPU. Teams must be fully formed and select Track A by the Wednesday deadline to be considered. If your team is not selected for the 10 hardware spots, you will be automatically redirected to compete in Track B, C, or D.

- **Pre-requisite**: Read the research paper "Optimization via Quantum Preconditioning" (Dupont et al.) provided during Wednesday's Resource Tour. For the full study resources guide, Click Here

Challenge Tracks & Pre-requisites

Track B: Quandela (Advanced)

- **Theme**: Option Pricing in Finance using Quantum Machine Learning (QML).

- **Difficulty**: Intermediate
  - Machine Learning background preferred

- **Pre-requisite**: All team members aiming for Track B must create a free account at [Click Here to Access Quandela's Training Platform] prior to Tuesday's technical workshop to access the MerLin SDK and tutorials. We highly encourage you to Visit This Repository for the full list of preparation materials.

Challenge Tracks & Pre-requisites

Track C: Classiq (Intermediate)

- **Theme**: Solving Linear Differential Equations
  - Quantum Harmonic Oscillator
- **Difficulty**: Intermediate
  - Physics/Math background helpful
- **Pre-requisite**: Review the "Classiq 101" documentation and the Tao Xin et al. (2020) paper during Wednesday's Resource Watch Party. The Preparation Guide can be found **here**.

Challenge Tracks & Pre-requisites

Track D: Infleqtion UK (Beginner Friendly)

- **Theme**: Quantum for Good / Social Impact.
- **Difficulty**: Beginner
  - Focuses on conceptual problem-solving, real-world impact, and system-level thinking.
- **Pre-requisite**: Brainstorm how quantum concepts can address UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). This prep guide might give you some confidence!

Submission Guidelines & Judging

How to Submit (Sunday, March 1 @ 3:00 PM ET):

One team member must submit the following items via the Aqora platform:

Code Repository
A public link to your team's GitHub repository containing your code and a detailed README.md file explaining how to run it. If you're a Track D hacker, submit a link to your Design Document or Prototype (e.g., Figma, Canva, or a PDF hosted on Google Drive) instead of code.

Summary Slide
A 1-page PDF summarizing the problem, your quantum approach, and the results.

Video Pitch
A maximum 3-minute video (hosted unlisted on YouTube or Google Drive) of your team presenting the project.

How You Will Be Judged:

Initial submissions will be graded by our Technical Mentors asynchronously. Each track has specific technical criteria, but all projects are generally weighted on:

- **Accuracy / Technical Merit**
- **Creativity / Novelty**
- **Presentation / Documentation**

The top team from each of the 4 tracks, plus 1 wildcard team, will advance to the Grand Finale on March 7 to pitch live to VIP Judges from NVIDIA, Oxford Quantum Circuits, Quantinuum, and QAI Ventures for the Grand Prize!

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The Much Awaited Prize Pool

- **Track A (Rigetti):**
  - Winner: **$1,850**
  - Runner-Up: **$950**
- **Track B (Quandela):**
  - Winner: **$1,850 + Quandela QPU Credits**
  - Runner-Up: **$950**
- **Track C (Classiq):**
  - Winner: **$650**
  - Runner-Up: **$250**
- **Track D (Infleqtion):**
  - Winner: $475 (Winner Takes All)

👑 GRAND CHAMPION (Best Overall Project):

Chosen from the 5 finalists, the Grand Champion team will receive **100,000 shots on an Oxford Quantum Circuits (OQC) superconducting quantum computer** to advance their research!

Need Help?

SOS

Hackathons are challenging, but you are not alone!

Technical Questions:

Post in your specific **#track-** channel on Discord during the Sprint. Mentors will be active during the designated Mentorship Blocks on Saturday.

Admin/Platform Questions:

Post in the **#help-desk channel**, and a Girls in Quantum organizer will assist you.

Remember: The goal is to learn, collaborate, and push the boundaries of what is possible. Have fun, drink water, and get some sleep!

Empowering the Future of Quantum.
— The Girls in Quantum Team

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